

The whitespace rule

HTML **collapses** every run of spaces, tabs and line breaks into a **single space**. You cannot create a blank line by pressing Enter. You need a tag.

YOU TYPE	BROWSER SHOWS
ten spaces	one space
five blank lines	one space
tab character	one space

```
<body>
  Welcome to my site
  My name is Alex
</body>

// browser renders:
Welcome to my site My name is Alex
```

Every tag in this lesson exists *because* of the whitespace rule. Spacing is a job you give to a tag.

Paragraphs — the <p> tag

```
<p>Welcome to my site</p>
<p>My name is Alex</p>
```

Each <p> creates a separate block with space above and below. The browser adds that space automatically — you never type it.

Welcome to my site

My name is Alex

two paragraphs, one gap between

Line breaks and dividers

TAG	PURPOSE	CLOSING TAG?	USE IT FOR
<p>	paragraph	Yes	A new idea. Space above and below.
 	line break	No	A new line inside the same idea. Addresses, poems, lyrics.
<hr>	topic divider	No	A change of subject. The horizontal line means "new topic."

```
<p>
  P. Sherman<br>
  42 Wallaby Way<br>
  Sydney, Australia
</p>
```

P. Sherman
42 Wallaby Way
Sydney, Australia

one paragraph, three lines

```
<p>Content above.</p>
<hr>
<p>Content below.</p>
```

Content above.

Content below.

one divider between two paragraphs

Never stack `<br><br><br>` to fake spacing. That is a CSS job (Unit 2). If you need space between two ideas, they are two `<p>` elements — not one paragraph with three empty lines.

Headings — six levels

```
<h1>Main Title</h1>
<h2>Major Section</h2>
<h3>Subsection</h3>
<h4>Sub-subsection</h4>
<h5>Minor Heading</h5>
<h6>Smallest Heading</h6>
```

Bigger number = smaller text. Sizes come from the browser and can be changed later with CSS.

Main Title

Major Section

Subsection

Sub-subsection

Minor Heading

Smallest Heading

browser defaults — not your choice

Three heading rules

1. One `<h1>` per page

It is the title of the whole page, like a book cover. Not section-level.

2. Never skip a level

`h1 → h3` is broken. `h1 → h2 → h3` is correct.

3. Make them descriptive

"Contact Information" — not "Section 2."

Why the order actually matters. A screen reader user navigates by jumping heading to heading. Your heading structure is their table of contents. Skipped levels sound like missing chapters.

Emphasis — four tags, two of them better

TAG	LOOKS LIKE	MEANS	SCREEN READER
<code></code>	bold	"this is important"	vocal emphasis
<code></code>	bold	"make this thicker"	reads flat
<code></code>	<i>italic</i>	"stress this"	vocal emphasis
<code><i></code>	<i>italic</i>	"visually different"	reads flat

Default to `<strong>` and `<em>`. They do everything `<b>` and `<i>` do, *plus* carry meaning. There is no downside. `<strong>` and `<em>` are **semantic** — they describe what content means, not how it looks.

Nesting — the rule

```
<strong><em>extremely</em></strong> ✓
<strong><em>extremely</strong></em> ✗
```

First opened, last closed. The inner tag closes before the outer tag.

Think of boxes. You put a small box *inside* a big box. The small box has to close first — you cannot close the big one while the small one is still open.

Same idea as parentheses in math: `( [ ] )`.

Comments — notes the browser ignores

```
<!-- This is a comment -->

<!-- Navigation section starts here -->
<h2>Menu</h2>
```

Invisible on the page. Visible to anyone reading your code — including future-you.

Use them to:

- Label sections in a long file
- Explain a decision you will forget
- Temporarily disable code without deleting it

Shortcut: Ctrl/Cmd + /

Today's tags — complete list

TAG	PURPOSE	CLOSING TAG?	NOTES
<h1>–<h6>	headings	Yes	One <code>h1</code> per page. Never skip levels.
<p>	paragraph	Yes	One idea per paragraph.
	important	Yes	Semantic. Screen readers hear it.
	emphasized	Yes	Semantic. Same as above.
 · <i>	visual only	Yes	Presentational. Avoid in new code.
 	line break	No	Inside one paragraph.
<hr>	divider	No	Means a topic change.

Common mistakes to avoid

MISTAKE	WHAT GOES WRONG
Crossed nesting — <code><i>text</i></code>	Browsers tolerate it in simple cases but it breaks in complex pages. Always close inner first.
Headings picked by size	Three <code><h1></code> tags on one page. Pick by meaning, not by how big it looks.
Bare text in <code><body></code>	Text with no <code><p></code> around it collapses together and has no structure.
Stacking <code>
</code> for spacing	Fakes what <code><p></code> or CSS should do. Breaks the moment you style the page.
Skipped heading level	<code><h1></code> then <code><h3></code> — reads as a missing chapter to screen reader users.

What is next. Your pages now have structure and text. Lesson 4 adds links — the thing that makes the web a *web*. Every anchor tag uses the same opening-tag-only attribute rule you learned today.

Keep this sheet. The whitespace rule and the heading order rules appear again in every later lesson.